

The **Indian Imperial Harem** (primarily during the Mughal era) was a highly organized, diverse institution composed of thousands of women, including royal wives (*Begums*), concubines (*Aghas* and *Aghachas*), and female servants (*dasis* or slave-girls). Far from a lawless pleasure house, it functioned like a sovereign city governed by strict hierarchies, administrative protocols, and meticulous daily care. [1, 2, 3, 4]

Races and Origins of the Women

The harem housed an empire-spanning assembly of women carefully segmented by political alliances, geographic origins, and perceived social value: [5, 6, 7, 8]

- **Foreign Origins (High Status Concubines & Guards):** Women from **Persia (Iran), Central Asia (Timurid/Mongol roots), Abyssinia (Ethiopia/East Africa), Circassia, and Georgia** were highly prized. Ethiopian and Tartar women were often deployed as fierce internal guards (*Urdu-begis*) because of their perceived physical strength and loyalty. [9, 10, 11]
 - **Indigenous Origins (Domestic/Labor Class):** **Local Indian women** from various provinces and conquered territories comprised the majority. While local Rajput princesses held elite status through strategic marriages, common local *dasis* were generally relegated to the lower administrative rungs, performing household labor and domestic tasks. [10, 12]
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Physical Attributes and Figures

Historical sources and Persian court miniatures describe the distinct physical attributes and figures idealised or recorded in the harem:

- **The Ideal Figure:** The ideal body type was voluptuous yet balanced—often described as having a **"moon-like" round face, full hips, and a narrow waist**, symbolizing fertility and elegance.
- **Foreign vs. Local Attributes:** Court documents and external travelers (like Niccolao Manucci and François Bernier) noted stark contrasts. Women from Persia and Central Asia were celebrated for their **fair, alabaster skin, sharp aquiline noses, and large almond-shaped eyes**. Conversely, local *dasis* assigned to manual labor were noted as having less delicate features and darker complexions. [10, 13]
- **Body Hair Treatment:** Women in the harem were **meticulously hairless** on their bodies. Hair removal was an absolute requirement of medieval courtly grooming. They utilized *Nura* (a traditional depilatory paste made from quicklime and arsenic) or sugaring wax to maintain entirely smooth skin. Head hair, however, was kept exceptionally long, dark, glossy, and braided.

Cleanliness, Hygiene, and Fragrance

The notion that the harem was unclean is an Orientalist myth; hygiene inside the imperial quarters was treated as a high art form, heavily influenced by Persian and Islamic water cultures: [3, 14]

- **Extreme Cleanliness:** The harem complex featured expansive **hammams (royal baths), running water channels, and marble fountains**. Inmates bathed daily, using natural exfoliants like chickpea flour paste (*ubtan* or *missi*), sandalwood, and crushed lentils to keep their skin soft and radiant. [3, 15, 16, 17, 18]
- **How They Smelled:** Scent was highly weaponized for seduction and royalty. Women infused their skin and garments with expensive **Rosewater, Musk, Ambergris, Oud, and Sandalwood**. Empress Nur Jahan herself was famous for inventing *Atr-i-Jahangiri*, an incredibly potent and highly coveted rose essential oil. [16, 19, 20]
- **Oral Hygiene:** To ensure sweet breath during royal visits, women chewed continuously on **Paan (betel leaf)** mixed with aromatic spices like cardamom, cloves, and lime paste, which stained their lips a vibrant, seductive red. [15]

Traditional Garments and Jewelry

The attire worn inside the *zenana* (female quarters) was fluid, luxurious, and heavily layered: [15, 19, 21]

- **The Peshwaz:** The primary garment was a **Peshwaz**, a high-waisted, long-sleeved flowing gown made of transparent, fine muslin or silk, worn over a short blouse (*choli*).
 - **Pajamas and Veils:** Underneath the gown, they wore tight, bias-cut trousers called **Churidar pajamas**. When moving within the harem, they draped transparent silk *dupattas* (scarves) across their shoulders. If they ever stepped outside the physical walls, they wore all-enveloping **burqas** to shield themselves from public eyes.
 - **Jewelry Extravaganza:** Mughal court records track up to **37 distinct types of female body ornaments**. Women were draped in heavy pearls, emeralds, and diamonds from head to toe. Iconic pieces included the **Nath** (a large jeweled nose ring symbolizing marital status), heavy gold anklets (*pajeb*), and intricate jeweled headpieces (*tika*). [15, 19, 22, 23, 24, 25]
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Diet and Aphrodisiac Preferences

The imperial kitchen (*Matbakh*) and specialized fruit houses (*Maywa Khanah*) provided highly curated, nutrient-dense, and energy-boosting meals to the harem: [3, 18, 20]

- **Daily Dietary Staples:** The elite ladies and their servants ate heavily spiced **Mughlai pulaos, slow-cooked meat stews (korma), unleavened breads, and a massive variety of fresh and dried fruits** (such as pomegranates, figs, and melons). [3, 20]
 - **Aphrodisiac Prefences:** To maintain sexual stamina and fertility for the emperor, special foods were prepared. These included **saffron-infused milks, gold and silver foil-covered sweetmeats (vark), soups simmered with bone marrow, and meats marinated with warming spices** like nutmeg, mace, and musk. [16, 18]
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Most Demanded Women for Harem Service

When it came to executing the complex daily administration, security, and personal pleasure of the court, specific groups were in exceptionally high demand:

- **The Kashmiri and Persian Women:** Highly sought after for their **wit, education, poetic abilities, and musical talents**. They were highly demanding of the emperor's sexual attention and were chosen as elite concubines because they could engage in elevated cultural conversations, making them the ultimate companions.
- **The Ethiopian (Habshi) and Tartar Women:** Demanded for their absolute **loyalty and formidable physical capabilities**. Because they were viewed as physically imposing and free from local Indian political biases, they were trusted explicitly to run the inner security matrix of the harem, preventing any outside male infiltration. [9, 16, 17, 26, 27]

[1] <https://en.banglapedia.org>

[2] <https://www.scribd.com>

[3] <https://en.wikipedia.org>

[4] <https://www.newindianexpress.com>

[5] <https://www.scribd.com>

[6] <https://www.scribd.com>

[7] <https://www.scribd.com>

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- [9] <https://dirosat.com>
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